

prove this successfully to the court, your spouse could walk away with everything.

The easiest way to protect yourself from financial ruin is to simply sign a cohabitation agreement with your common-law partner. I covered these in detail in my last book, but here's a quick recap: this is a written agreement that lays out how you will deal with your property should your relationship end. You should absolutely include a clause in your cohabitation agreement that makes you and your partner subject to the same family law rules governing division of property for married couples.

MYTH #3: Going on a spending binge in the twilight of your marriage feels great, and you're spending your soon-to-be ex's money, not your own!

Wrong. It *does* cost you. If you "treat" yourself to a decadent shopping spree, splurging on a new home-entertainment system or 12 pairs of shoes, *you are dipping into your own fortune*. I once had a woman tell me she was so angry at her philandering husband that she charged \$18,000 worth of new clothes on his credit card the week before the divorce. I had to remind her that 50 cents of every dollar her husband made was hers. She might have thought she was spending his paycheck, but actually she was spending her own!

MYTH #4: The excitement dies as the marriage lasts.

This does not have to be true. Treat your marriage as an investment and it will pay off. Don't ignore the benefits and the real worth just because partners are familiar and you see them every day. Remember: a strong family dynasty will come from a